

Lab 3.3: Draft a Performance Improvement Plan

Introduction

This hands-on lab gives you practice turning a performance review into a focused, four-week improvement plan. Working from a sample performance review, you will diagnose the real bottleneck, set specific and measurable goals, and lay out weekly milestones. The goal is to practice the discipline of fixing the right thing rather than working harder at everything.

Learning Objectives

After completing this lab, you will be able to:

- Diagnose a performance bottleneck from review data.
- Set specific, measurable, time-bound improvement goals.
- Build a four-week plan with milestones and success metrics.



Scenario

You are an Account Executive at PayPro Solutions. Your manager has shared the following performance review with you, and asked you to build a four-week plan to improve. The focus is your demo-to-proposal conversion rate.

Sample performance review data (last quarter):

Funnel stage	Your numbers	Team benchmark
Outreach to meeting	Strong, above benchmark	On track
Meetings booked	40 demos delivered	Healthy volume
Demo to proposal	Demos delivered: 40; Proposals sent: 12 (30%)	Team average: 45%
Proposal to close	Proposals: 12; Closed: 6 (50%)	Team average: 50%

Manager's note: Your activity is strong and your closing rate on proposals is fine. The gap is that too few demos turn into proposals. Something in the demo itself is not converting.

Your task is to build a one-page, four-week improvement plan focused on the demo-to-proposal bottleneck.

Tools Overview

Reading: Optimization Playbook Principles

The method from this lesson: diagnose the specific bottleneck, test one change at a time, and set a few measurable, time-bound goals with a review rhythm. These principles are covered in depth in this reading.

Resource Files

Lab 3.3 Exemplar Solution (DOCX)

Supporting lesson resource: Reading: Performance Optimization Playbook

Note: This lab intentionally uses no plan template. Structuring the diagnosis, goal, and milestones yourself is part of the skill being practiced.

Instructions

Exercise 1: Diagnose and Set a Goal

Objective: Confirm the bottleneck and turn it into a measurable goal.

Step 1: Name the bottleneck

Using the review data, confirm where the funnel breaks. The numbers point clearly to one stage. State it, and resist the urge to fix stages that are already healthy.

Step 2: Write a SMART goal

Write one specific, measurable, time-bound goal that targets the bottleneck. It should name the metric, the target, and the timeframe. You do not need five goals; one sharp one is better.

Exercise 2: Build the Four-Week Plan

Objective: Lay out weekly milestones and success metrics.

Step 1: Plan the weeks

Break the four weeks into milestones. Think about what to change in the demo, how to test it one variable at a time, and how to check whether it is working. Keep the changes focused.

Step 2: Define success metrics

State how you will measure success, the specific number that tells you the plan worked, and the review rhythm you will use to track it.

Lab Output / Expected Outcome

By the end of this lab, you should have a one-page improvement plan that includes:

- A clear statement of the diagnosed bottleneck.

- One SMART goal targeting it.

- A four-week plan with weekly milestones and a defined success metric and review rhythm.

Summary

Congratulations! You have completed this lab. In this activity, you practiced diagnosing performance bottlenecks, setting measurable improvement goals, and creating a structured plan for sustained progress. This type of performance planning is a foundational sales development skill that helps professionals focus improvement efforts where they will have the greatest impact and drive stronger results over time.
